

**FILING INSTRUCTIONS -- 14TH CIRCUIT COURT, MUSKEGON
COUNTY**

**COMPLETE FILING GUIDE FOR THE 14TH CIRCUIT COURT
FILING STACK**

CASE NO. 2024-001507-DC | PIGORS V. WATSON

Prepared: March 04, 2026

I. OVERVIEW OF FILINGS

This guide provides step-by-step instructions for filing the complete 14th Circuit Court motion stack in the case of Pigors v. Watson, Case No. 2024-001507-DC. The stack consists of the following filings:

#	Filing	Priority	Est. Fee
1	Emergency Motion Packet (Restore Parenting Time)	**HIGHEST**	\$175.00
2	Motion to Set Aside Ex Parte Orders	HIGH	\$175.00
3	Motion to Disqualify Judge McNeill	HIGH	\$175.00
4	Motion for Contempt	HIGH	\$175.00
5	Motion to Modify Custody	MEDIUM	\$175.00
6	Motion to Modify Child Support	MEDIUM	\$175.00
TOTAL			**\$1,050.00**

Note: If filing a fee waiver (MC 20), no fees are required until the waiver is ruled upon. See Section IV below.

II. MIFILE ELECTRONIC FILING PROCEDURES

A. MiFILE Account Setup

1. Navigate to **<https://mifile.courts.michigan.gov>**
2. If you do not already have an account, click "Register" and create an account
3. Verify your email address
4. Log in to your MiFILE account

B. Locating the Case

1. After logging in, click "File into Existing Case"
2. Select **Court:** "14th Circuit Court - Muskegon County"
3. Enter **Case Number:** 2024-001507-DC
4. Click "Search" to locate the case
5. Verify the case caption: Pigors v. Watson

C. Filing a Motion

For each motion in the stack:

1. Click "File into Existing Case" and locate Case No. 2024-001507-DC
2. Select **Filing Type**: "Motion"
3. Select **Document Type** appropriate to the filing:
 - Emergency Motion --> "Emergency Motion"
 - Motion to Set Aside --> "Motion"
 - Motion to Disqualify --> "Motion to Disqualify Judge"
 - Motion for Contempt --> "Motion for Order to Show Cause"
 - Motion to Modify Custody --> "Motion to Modify"
 - Motion to Modify Support --> "Motion to Modify Support"
4. Upload the motion document (PDF format required)
5. Upload any supporting exhibits
6. Add a brief description in the "Filing Comments" field
7. Review the filing for completeness
8. Submit and pay the filing fee (or request fee waiver)
9. **SAVE THE CONFIRMATION NUMBER** for each filing

D. Document Format Requirements

- * **Format**: PDF only (convert .md files to PDF before filing)
- * **Page size**: 8.5" x 11" (Letter)
- * **Margins**: Minimum 1" on all sides
- * **Font**: 12-point, standard readable font (Times New Roman, Arial, or similar)

- * **Line spacing:** Double-spaced for body text
- * **Page numbers:** Bottom center
- * **Caption:** First page of each document must include full case caption

E. Converting Markdown to PDF

To convert the .md files to properly formatted PDF:

1. **Option A -- Microsoft Word:** Open .md in a text editor, copy content to Word, format per court requirements, Save As PDF
2. **Option B -- Online converter:** Use a markdown-to-PDF converter (e.g., md2pdf, pandoc)
3. **Option C -- Command line:** ``pandoc motion_file.md -o motion_file.pdf --pdf-engine=wkhtmltopdf``
4. **CRITICAL:** After conversion, review each PDF to ensure:
 - Caption is properly formatted
 - Page numbers are present
 - All text is readable
 - No formatting artifacts

III. FILING FEES

A. Standard Motion Fee

* **Motion filing fee:** \$175.00 per motion

* **Total for all six motions:** \$1,050.00

* **Payment methods accepted by MiFILE:** Credit card, debit card, electronic check

B. Fee Waiver (MC 20)

If you cannot afford the filing fees, you may request a fee waiver:

1. Download **Form MC 20 -- Fee Waiver Request** from the Michigan Courts website:

<https://www.courts.michigan.gov/siteassets/forms/scao-approved/mc20.pdf>

2. Complete the form, providing:

- Current income information
- Monthly expenses
- Assets and debts
- Reason for requesting waiver

3. File the MC 20 **BEFORE** or **WITH** your first motion

4. If the waiver is granted, all filing fees for the case are waived

5. If the waiver is denied, you will be required to pay the fees within a specified time

C. Fee Waiver Tips

* Be thorough and accurate in reporting income and expenses

* Include documentation of income (pay stubs, tax returns)

- * If currently unemployed or underemployed due to incarceration history, state this clearly
- * The fee waiver applies to all filings in the case, not just the first one
- * File the fee waiver first to avoid paying fees that may later be waived

IV. SERVICE OF PROCESS -- MCR 2.107

A. Who Must Be Served

All motions must be served on:

1. Defendant Emily M. Watson (or her attorney of record)
2. Friend of the Court (for custody and support motions)
3. Any Guardian Ad Litem appointed in the case
4. Any other party of record

B. Methods of Service

MCR 2.107 authorizes the following methods of service:

1. **MiFILE electronic service:** If all parties are registered MiFILE users, electronic filing provides automatic service. This is the preferred method.
2. **Email service:** If the parties have stipulated to email service, or if the Court has ordered email service, send a copy to the email address on file.

3. **First-class mail:** Mail a copy to the party's last known address. **Important:** If serving by mail, you must serve at least **7 days before the hearing date** (MCR 2.107(C)(3) adds 3 days to the notice period for mail service, in addition to the standard notice period).

4. **Personal service:** Deliver a copy directly to the party or their attorney.

C. Certificate of Service

Each filing **MUST** include a Certificate of Service stating:

- * The date of service
- * The method of service
- * The name and address of each person served
- * A signature under oath or declaration

D. Service Timeline

Method	Additional Time Required
MiFILE (electronic)	Same day (no additional time)
Email (if stipulated)	+1 day
First-class mail	+3 days added to notice period
Personal service	Same day

V. HEARING SCHEDULING -- MCR 2.119(C)

A. Motion Day

MCR 2.119(C) provides that each court shall designate specific motion days. For the 14th Circuit Court, Muskegon County:

- * **Motion days:** [Check with clerk -- typically Tuesday or Wednesday mornings]
- * **Motion call time:** [Typically 8:30 AM or 9:00 AM]
- * **Location:** Hall of Justice, 990 Terrace Street, Muskegon, MI 49442

B. Notice Requirements

- * **Standard motions:** 9 days' notice before the hearing (MCR 2.119(C)(1))
- * **Add 3 days** if serving by mail (total: 12 days before hearing)
- * **Emergency motions:** May be heard on shortened notice per MCR 2.119(B)(7)
- * **Motion to Disqualify:** Must be heard within 14 days per MCR 2.003(D)(2)

C. Scheduling Procedure

1. **Standard motions:** File the motion via MiFILE. The clerk will assign a hearing date on the next available motion day, or you may be required to contact the clerk to schedule.
2. **Emergency motions:** File via MiFILE with "Emergency" designation. Contact the clerk's office immediately by telephone to request expedited scheduling.
3. **Disqualification motion:** This must be decided by the chief judge or another judge if Judge McNeill does not grant it. The MCR 2.003 timeline controls.

D. Hearing Preparation

For each hearing, prepare:

1. Three copies of the motion and all exhibits (for the Court, yourself, and opposing party)
2. A proposed order for the Court's signature
3. Any additional evidence you intend to present
4. A brief outline of your oral argument (2-3 minutes per motion)
5. Copies of key cases you intend to cite

VI. MUSKEGON COUNTY LOCAL RULES AND INFORMATION

A. Court Information

- * **Court:** 14th Circuit Court for the County of Muskegon
- * **Address:** Michael E. Kobza Hall of Justice, 990 Terrace Street, Muskegon, MI 49442
- * **Phone:** (231) 724-6241 (Clerk's Office)
- * **Hours:** Monday - Friday, 8:00 AM - 5:00 PM
- * **Website:** <https://www.co.muskegon.mi.us/395/Circuit-Court>

B. Friend of the Court

- * **Office:** Muskegon County Friend of the Court
- * **Address:** 990 Terrace Street, Muskegon, MI 49442 (same building as Circuit Court)

- * **Phone:** (231) 724-6289
- * **Fax:** (231) 724-6588
- * **Hours:** Monday - Friday, 8:00 AM - 5:00 PM

C. Local Administrative Orders

Check for any local administrative orders that may affect filing procedures:

- * **COVID-19 protocols:** May still affect in-person hearing availability
- * **Electronic hearing procedures:** The Court may conduct hearings via Zoom or telephone
- * **Local motion practice:** Some local rules may modify MCR provisions

D. Pro Se Resources

- * **Self-Help Center:** The courthouse may have a self-help center for pro se litigants
- * **Michigan Legal Help:** <https://michiganlegalhelp.org> (free legal information and forms)
- * **Muskegon County Bar Association:** May offer referral services or limited-scope representation

VII. FILING SEQUENCE AND TIMELINE

Recommended Filing Order

CRITICAL: File in the following order for maximum strategic effect:

Week 1 -- Emergency and Foundation Filings

Day	Action	Filing
Day 1	File fee waiver (if needed)	MC 20 Fee Waiver Request
Day 1	File emergency motion	emergency_motion_packet.md
Day 1	Call clerk to request emergency hearing	N/A
Day 2	File motion to set aside	motion_set_aside_orders.md
Day 3	File motion to disqualify	motion_disqualify_mcneill.md

Week 2 -- Enforcement and Modification Filings

Day	Action	Filing
Day 8	File motion for contempt	motion_contempt.md
Day 9	File motion to modify custody	motion_modify_custody.md
Day 10	File motion to modify support	motion_modify_child_support.md

Ongoing -- Follow-Up Actions

Timeframe	Action
Day 1-3	Confirm receipt of all filings via MiFILE
Day 3-5	Verify service on all parties
Day 7-14	Attend emergency hearing (if scheduled)
Day 14-21	Attend motion hearing for remaining motions
Ongoing	Check MiFILE for court orders and responses

VIII. FILING CHECKLIST

Use this checklist for each motion filing:

Pre-Filing

- * ☐ Motion document reviewed for accuracy
- * ☐ Case caption correct (Case No. 2024-001507-DC)
- * ☐ Converted to PDF format
- * ☐ Page numbers present
- * ☐ Certificate of Service included
- * ☐ Verification/signature page included
- * ☐ Proposed Order attached
- * ☐ All exhibits properly labeled and attached
- * ☐ Fee waiver filed (if applicable)

Filing

- * ☐ Logged into MiFILE
- * ☐ Correct case selected
- * ☐ Correct document type selected
- * ☐ PDF uploaded
- * ☐ Filing fee paid (or waiver pending)
- * ☐ Filing confirmation number saved: _____
- * ☐ Filing timestamp noted: _____

Post-Filing

- * ☐ Service completed on Defendant / Defendant's attorney

- * ☐ Service completed on Friend of the Court (custody/support motions)
- * ☐ Service completed on Guardian Ad Litem (if appointed)
- * ☐ Certificate of Service filed
- * ☐ Hearing date confirmed: _____
- * ☐ Calendar entry created for hearing
- * ☐ Hearing preparation materials assembled

IX. IMPORTANT DEADLINES AND REMINDERS

1. **Emergency motions:** No specific deadline, but file as soon as possible. Every day of delay adds to the harm.
2. **Motion to disqualify:** MCR 2.003(D)(2) -- must be decided within 14 days of filing unless extended by the chief judge.
3. **Standard motions:** Must be noticed for hearing at least 9 days in advance (12 days if serving by mail).
4. **Responses:** Opposing party has 7 days to file a response (MCR 2.119(C)(2)).
5. **Replies:** Moving party may file a reply within 4 days of the response (MCR 2.119(C)(3)).
6. **Support modification:** File a current Uniform Child Support Order (UCSO) with the motion.

X. TROUBLESHOOTING

MiFILE Issues

- * **Cannot find case:** Verify case number exactly: 2024-001507-DC. Try searching by party name.
- * **Upload fails:** Ensure PDF is under 25MB. Split large documents if necessary.
- * **Payment fails:** Try a different payment method. Contact MiFILE support: support@mifile.courts.michigan.gov or (517) 373-0130.
- * **Filing rejected:** Check rejection reason. Common issues: incorrect document type, missing caption, wrong case number. Correct and refile promptly.

Service Issues

- * **Cannot locate Defendant:** File a motion for alternative service (MCR 2.105).
- * **Defendant refuses service:** Document the refusal and file an affidavit of attempted service.
- * **Electronic service bounces:** Switch to first-class mail and add 3 days to the notice period.

Hearing Issues

- * **Hearing not scheduled:** Call the clerk's office at (231) 724-6241 to inquire.
- * **Need to adjourn:** File a motion to adjourn at least 3 business days before the hearing.
- * **Remote hearing:** If the hearing is by Zoom, test your connection and equipment beforehand. Dress professionally. Treat it as an in-person hearing.

XI. FINAL NOTES

1. **Keep copies of everything.** Maintain a complete file of all documents filed, served, and received.
2. **Document all communications.** Keep a log of all calls to the clerk, service attempts, and communications with opposing counsel.
3. **Be professional.** All filings should be professionally formatted, clearly written, and respectful in tone.
4. **Follow up.** Do not assume that filing a motion will automatically result in a hearing. Follow up with the clerk's office to confirm hearing dates.
5. **Prepare for hearings.** Each motion hearing is an opportunity to present your case. Be organized, concise, and focused on the facts and law.
6. **Stay current.** Court rules and local practices may change. Check the Michigan Courts website and Muskegon County local rules for updates.

This filing guide is part of the 14th Circuit Court Filing Stack for Pigors v. Watson, Case No. 2024-001507-DC. It is intended as a procedural reference and does not constitute legal advice.